

The Theology of the Trinity — Volume III

Later Eras, Disputed Questions, and Trinitarian Life

Third volume in the study series. Prepared 17 July 2026. All quotations are drawn verbatim from the sources in the source notebook (Emery & Levering, eds., The Oxford Handbook of the Trinity; Kärkkäinen, Christian Understandings of the Trinity; a Brief History of the Doctrine of the Trinity; the Cambridge Companion to the Trinity; Moltmann, The Trinity and the Kingdom; and cited primary texts), with the notebook's internal citations retained.

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1. The Reformation and Anti-Trinitarianism

The Reformers shifted Trinitarian theology "from scholastic, metaphysical speculation to a more pastoral and soteriological framework centered on the 'economy of salvation.'" "Neither Calvin nor Luther, by virtue of their fundamentally biblical orientation... engaged in the scholastic method."

Martin Luther integrated the Trinity with his theology of the cross and of self-giving love:

"These are the three persons and one God, who has given himself to us all wholly and completely, with all that he is and has. The Father gives himself... the Son himself subsequently gave himself... the Holy Spirit comes and gives himself to us also."

Christ is the sole access to God — he "unguardedly overstates: 'Apart from Christ, there is no God.'" On terminology, Luther held that "Our adversaries... are fanatics about words, because they want us to demonstrate the truth of the trinitarian article... by asking us to assent to the term *homoousios*" — for him "the *res* has priority over its corresponding *verbum*."

John Calvin gave "a biblically based exposition that largely avoids philosophical terminologies," quoting Gregory of Nazianzus: "I cannot think of the unity without being irradiated by the Trinity: I cannot distinguish between the Trinity without being carried up to the unity." Against Servetus and Gentile he developed the **Son as *autotheos** ("*God of himself*"): "*preserving the full deity of the Son requires us to confess that he is autotheos**, God of himself." The nuance: "the fact that the Son is 'God of himself' reflects a truth about his consubstantial divine essence... whereas the fact that he is 'begotten of the Father' reflects a truth about his unique divine personhood." "Calvin holds that the Son has his divinity from himself, just as the Father does."

The Council of Trent stayed sober on the mystery of indwelling: "the Council of Trent contents itself with a simple statement of the reality of the Holy Spirit within us."

Anti-Trinitarianism. *Sola scriptura* gave rise to "biblical anti-trinitarianism."

- **Michael Servetus** (executed at Geneva) "was absolutely committed to the authority of Scripture, but regarded the doctrine of the Trinity to be a later distortion of biblical truth, rooted in Greek philosophy rather than in the Scriptures."
- **The Socinians** — Faustus Socinus: "the existence of three persons in one nature was contradictory"; to "safeguard the unity and oneness of God" they held "Jesus's deity is not affirmed but, rather, his humanity." The *Racovian Catechism* (1605) taught "that God is unipersonal... since a person is 'an individual intelligent essence.'"
- **Early Unitarianism** merged biblical skepticism with Enlightenment rationalism.

2. Later-Medieval Scholasticism — Lombard, Scotus, Ockham

Peter Lombard's *Sentences* became the standard medieval textbook, its first book treating "God one and triune... the processions of the Son then of the Holy Spirit." Joachim of Fiore attacked Lombard for holding that "neither has the Father engendered the divine substance, nor has the divine essence engendered the Son," alleging a "quaternity"; but Lombard so wrote "in order to avoid coming to the conclusion that the Father engendered himself," and "Against Joachim's charges, the fourth Lateran Council in 1215 proclaimed the orthodoxy of the Lombard." His identification of "charity and the Holy Spirit" was later set aside though never condemned.

John Duns Scotus (d. 1308) made "a near total rejection of the relation account": "the persons were absolutes, constituted by absolute origin," and "the constitutive... feature of each produced person is the very production of that person, and this production has no quiddity or nature of its own." He relied on the first/second-substance distinction — "the divine essence is a nature or a quiddity (i.e. a second substance)... the divine person is first substance or individual supposite" — and introduced the **formal distinction**: "a distinction in something prior to any act of the intellect, yet less than a fully real distinction," by which "intellect and will are formally distinct both from each other and from the divine essence." He used it to defuse the expository syllogism: "there is nevertheless a formal distinction between them — the Father is not purely or absolutely identical with the essence."

William of Ockham (1280–1349), fideist and nominalist, "postulated that the doctrine could be believed only by the authority of the church." Nominalism sharpened the problem: "if one retains the concept of a substance that unites the three persons, then it represents a fourth entity... If, however, the three persons are not united by one substance, then they constitute three distinct and separate entities, thus representing tritheism." Yet "although William of Ockham thought Scotus' formal distinction to be unintelligible, nevertheless he accepted that person and essence are formally distinct precisely because he could see no other way to guarantee the universality of Aristotelian logic."

3. ***Vestigia Trinitatis***, Analogy, and Natural Knowledge of the Trinity

Trinity and creation. Irenaeus rejected intermediaries with the "two hands" image: "For with him were always present the Word and Wisdom, the Son and the Spirit by whom and in whom, freely, he made all things." **Aquinas**: "God the Father made the creature through his Word, which is the Son, and through his love, which is the Holy Spirit... processions of the persons are the *rationes* for the production of creatures." **Moltmann** goes further: "creation is actually a product of the Father's love and is ascribed to the whole Trinity... He creates out of the powers and energies of his own Spirit."

Vestigia Trinitatis. Augustine (on Rom 1:20): "When therefore we regard the Creator, who is understood by the things that are made we must needs understand the Trinity of whom there appear traces in the creature, as is fitting." **Bonaventure**: "The created world is like a book in which its Maker, the trinity, shines forth... as a vestige, as an image, and as a similitude." **Hugh of St Victor** correlated power/wisdom/goodness with immensity/beauty/utility. **Aquinas**: "all creatures bear a trace of the Trinity (*vestigium Trinitatis*)... as (i) a subsisting, existing thing having (ii) definite form and intelligibility and (iii) as being inclined, ordered or related to another as its end."

Analogy and its limits. Augustine used the psychological analogies (memory/understanding/will; lover/beloved/love) "not to derive the trinity from the unity but to simply illustrate the Trinity in whom one already believes," insisting "If you understand, it is not God." Volf: "Our notions of the triune God are not the triune God."

Natural knowledge. Richard of St Victor was optimistic ("there is no lack of not merely plausible but even irrefutable arguments for any truth"). **Aquinas** set the standard boundary: "It is impossible to come to the knowledge of the Trinity of divine persons through natural reason... through natural reason we can know what has to do with the unity of nature, but not with the distinction of persons." Worse, "He who tries to prove the trinity of persons by natural powers of reason detracts from faith in two ways"; analogies show only *fittingness*: "granted that one accepts the Trinity there are certain confirmations from the fittingness of things, yet not so much as may prove the Trinity of persons conclusively."

4. The Trinity in German Idealism and the Nineteenth Century

Kant judged the Trinity "a mystery surpassing all human concepts"; Schleiermacher relegated it to an appendix. German Idealism instead brought "to the centre of philosophy the idea of a triadic dynamic encompassing all of reality."

Hegel made the Trinity the supreme symbol of his system: "the unfolding of the history of the world... is but the process of the Spirit, ultimately the Spirit becoming conscious of itself." Moltmann: "Ever since Hegel in particular, the Christian Trinity has tended to be represented in terms belonging to the general concept of the absolute subject: one subject — three modes of being... an eternal process of self-differentiation and self-identification of the absolute subject." Hegel mapped the dialectic onto the economy: "The Father creates that which is not-God; the Son becomes that which is not-God and embraces total otherness from the Father — death — to bring about reconciliation, the Spirit-filled eschaton." But he "rejects a tri-personal divinity in favour of a self-realizing triadic dynamic," the persons becoming "vanishing moments." Substantively the grounding reverses: "It is the economy... that retrospectively gives authentic reality to the immanent sphere."

Influence. Hegel's reading "freed nineteenth-century theology from the exegetical preoccupations of eighteenth-century theology." Dorner "viewed God as a harmony of opposites"; von Hofmann: "In eternity, God determined to become Father, Son, and Spirit for the sake of this history." Moltmann charges that transferring subjectivity to the one essence in Barth and Rahner ("one divine subject in three... modes of being") is "a late triumph for the Sabellian modalism." Moltmann and Pannenberg both "expressed their debt to Hegel."

5. The Historiographical Turn — the "de Régnon Paradigm" and its Critics

The paradigm, from the Jesuit **Théodore de Régnon**, posits an East–West divide: "Latin philosophy envisages first the nature in itself and then proceeds to the expression; Greek philosophy envisages first the expression and then penetrates it to find the nature" — i.e. "Latin Trinitarianism, supremely represented by Augustine, started with the one God, and asked how he could be triune; by contrast Greek Trinitarianism began with the three hypostases."

De Régnon originally argued "for the necessity of both," but twentieth-century usage inverted it — "Augustine is held not to have understood the Cappadocian achievement" — producing "a caricatured distinction between Greek patristic 'personalism'... and Latin scholastic 'essentialism,'" and the charge that the Latin model harboured a "unitarian tendency."

Critique. The framework has been "severely, and rightly, criticized, as a gross and misleading oversimplification, especially when Augustine and Aquinas are included." **Barnes** argues Augustine has been "grossly misrepresented." **Ayres and Barnes** show "Augustine's concern in the book is largely polemical... at the heart of the polemic is an ongoing engagement with the Homoian tradition." **Holmes** declares "the falsity of what is called... the 'de Régnon thesis'; recent scholarship holds that "the patristic inheritance, East and West, essentially spoke with one voice," built on the axioms that "the three persons work inseparably *ad extra*" and "the logic of the simplicity of God."

6. Twentieth-Century Systematics — Lonergan, Pannenberg, Gunton, Torrance

Bernard Lonergan (transcendental Thomist): his *Verbum* "overcame centuries of misinterpretation," and he praised Augustine's *De Trinitate* as "the high-water mark in Christian attempts to reach an understanding of the faith." "The heart of Lonergan's trinitarian theology lies in his dissection of Nicaea": "if the statements of Nicaea... are presented to us as *answers*, it is incumbent upon us... to come to know the *questions* which they are proposed to answer." His followers show the psychological analogy "can continue fruitfully to serve theology's endeavour to mediate the meaning of the trinitarian mystery."

Wolfhart Pannenberg reverses the dogmatic order, beginning with the threeness. The persons are "not 'different modes of being of the one divine subject,' but rather 'living realizations of separate centers of action.'" Using Hegelian self-distinction: "one gains one's personality by giving oneself to one's counterpart," yielding "dependent divinity" — even "the Father's fatherhood is dependent on the Son." Controversially: "Even in his deity... [God] has made himself dependent on the course of history"; divine unity is "realized in relation to the world" and "completed only eschatologically."

Colin Gunton: "Suddenly we are all trinitarians, or so it would seem." He "casts a sweeping indictment against Western thought," but Cunningham faults *The One, the Three and the Many* for a "Parmenidean... versus Heraclitean" scheme, a "surrender to the dichotomous 'either/or' mentality."

T. F. Torrance: on Athanasius identifying the *ousia* with the fountain of procession, "While this model might overcome the whole dispute regarding the *Filioque*... it also presents the great disadvantage of not being able to describe the specific office of the Father." (Alan Torrance separately faults Moltmann for "Pelagian tendencies" in his doxology.)

7. The Trinity, Christology, and the Economy of Salvation

The Church took over *oikonomia* to designate "God's saving plan and its implementation in salvation history." "The *oikonomia*, says Tertullian... develops the divine unity into a trinity." Aquinas ties the economic missions to the eternal processions: "The mission of the divine person is, so to say, an outflowing in time of his eternal procession."

Incarnation. Rahner grounds the identity axiom in the Incarnation: "Jesus is not simply God in general, but the Son... there is at least one 'mission'... which is not merely appropriated to some divine person, but which is proper to him." **Weinandy:** "The drama of the cross... mirrors the life within the Trinity. The Father eternally begets his Son in the Spirit of love... On earth, as man, in the Spirit of love, the Son, by his filial obedience to the Father, offered his human life." **Jüngel:** "The crucified Christ is... nothing less than a trace or vestige of the Trinity (*vestigium Trinitatis*)."
Von Balthasar: "Jesus is the person who so completely accepts, lives out, and identifies himself with his mission that whereas others may have a mission, he simply *is* his mission."

Reintegration. LaCugna warns the *theologia/oikonomia* split gave "a one-sided theology that had little to do with the economy of Christ and the Spirit." Rahner's axiom repairs it: "The 'economic' Trinity is the 'immanent' Trinity and the 'immanent' Trinity is the 'economic' Trinity." Moltmann pushes to eschatology: "The economic Trinity completes and perfects itself to immanent Trinity when the history and experience of salvation are completed and perfected."

8. The Trinity in Worship, Prayer, Mysticism, and Iconography

Liturgy as source of faith. "*Lex orandi, lex credendi*." **Basil:** "As we are baptized, so, also, do we believe; as we believe, so, also, do we give glory."

Baptism. Moltmann: "The doctrine of the Trinity has baptism as its original *Sitz im Leben*."

Gregory of Nazianzus: "If He [the Holy Spirit] is not to be worshipped, how can He deify me by Baptism?" **Cyril of Jerusalem:** "At the same moment you both died and were born; that saving water became your tomb but also your mother."

Eucharist and doxology. The liturgy proceeds "giving thanks to the Father, remembering the saving deeds of the Son, and calling on the Spirit." Basil defended two doxological patterns — the **mediatorial** (Father *through* the Son *in* the Spirit, reflecting the economy) and the **co-ordinate** (Father *with* the Son *and* the Spirit — the *Gloria Patri* — reflecting the immanent Trinity, "equal in majesty, undivided in splendour").

Prayer and mysticism. St Patrick's Breastplate: "I arise today / Through... the invocation of the Trinity, / Through the belief in the threeness, / Through the confession of the oneness." **John of the Cross:** "the soul united and transformed in God breathes out in God to God the very divine spiration." **Catherine of Siena** altered the *Gloria*: "Glory be to the Father and to Thee and to the Holy Ghost." **Elizabeth of the Trinity** found her vocation in the indwelling of all three persons in her soul.

Iconography. Early art obeyed "Christomorphism": "God could be painted, but only God made man." From the twelfth century five families emerged — the Throne of Grace, the Psalter Trinity, the Paternity, the Triandric Trinity, and the (later prohibited) Tricephalous Trinity. In the East, **Andrei Rublev's** fifteenth-century icon (from Gen 18) is the pinnacle, set as the standard by a 1928 Moscow synod. **Moltmann:** "Through their tenderly intimate inclination towards one another, the three Persons show the profound unity joining them... The chalice on the table points to the surrender of the Son on Golgotha... it is only in the unity with one another which springs from the self-giving of the Son 'for many' that men and women are in conformity with the triune God."

All texts and quotations retrieved verbatim from the notebook's sources with their internal citations preserved. Third volume in the study series (main study + Primary-Source Companion + this). Further material — the Judaism/Islam essays, Bulgakov and Russian sophiology, or a consolidated single-volume edition — available on request.